

Group Chat Dynamics



BIG IDEA Group chats can turn from fun to harmful fast. You can save evidence without spreading it, support a target, and know when something is too big for the group and needs an adult now.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: Workbook CF-9; R9 Escalation Meter cards (12) per group of 4 to 5; wall signs ANNOYING, HURTING, TELL NOW; upstander phrase cards.

- ☐ Post the three signs on the wall.
- ☐ Copy 12 Escalation Meter cards per group.
- ☐ Know how your school takes cyberbullying reports.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hackles up? When a chat feels off or too heated, notice it. You do not have to be sure before you pause or tell someone. “Group chats are where friendships live. They can also be where things go sideways. A joke starts small, the group piles on, and someone feels left out or hurt. That is cyberbullying. Today’s case file is about a chat that got loud. Our job: work out when it crosses from annoying to harmful, what to save, and what to do. Every chat in the files is made up, so describe no real chats or people. It is never the target’s fault when a group piles on.”

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “What was the first moment someone could have changed the direction?”
- 2** “What is the difference between annoying and hurting? Who decides?”
- 3** “How can a screenshot help, and how can it harm?”

FUN BOOST Human Meter. Post ANNOYING, HURTING and TELL NOW on three walls. Read a card; students walk to a wall and may switch after a neighbor’s reason.

LEVEL-UP Chat Agreement. Write a five-norm agreement for a friend group, with what happens when a norm is broken, and pitch it in 30 seconds.

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *The Escalation Meter*

- 1 (1 min) Read CF-9.** In a class chat, someone posts a goofy photo of Tess with a mean caption. Laughing faces. “Let’s all stop talking to Tess.” Someone screenshots the chat into another group. Tess leaves. Amir saw it all and did nothing.
- 2 (5 min) Escalation Meter.** **ANNOYING:** rude, not harming. **HURTING:** repeated meanness, exclusion, humiliation. **TELL NOW:** threats, hate, sexual pictures or pressure, self-harm talk, private information spread. Groups place 12 cards and write the first move: ignore, support privately, say something kind, save evidence, report, tell an adult.
- 3 (1 min) Save, do not spread.** Save words, usernames and times, never the hurtful image, and never forward it. A private or sexual picture of anyone under 18: do not save or forward; tell an adult at once.
- 4 (1 min) Upstander phrases.** “Not cool. Let’s stop.” “I am leaving this chat.” “Hey, are you okay?” (private message) “I will go with you to tell someone.”

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause before you add to a pile-on. Check where it sits on the meter. Tell an adult when it is hurting or worse. You do not have to fix it alone. It is never the target’s fault, and a small kind move from you can change a chat.”

Hand signal: Hackles Up (hand brushed up the neck, optional), then Pause, Check, Tell. Post it: “Annoying: ignore. Hurting: speak up. Tell-now: tell an adult.”

EXIT TICKET “Write one sentence you could say or send if a group chat started to pile on someone.”

DIFFERENTIATE Give sentence frames for upstander phrases, eight cards, and picture icons for the signs.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “If a chat ever got mean, what would you do? Who would you tell?” Reassure your child they will not lose their phone for telling you.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “Just ignore it” or “Are you sure?”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”
- Asking to see messages, photos or accounts.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.